me, as a natural consequence, into the field of composite materials.

It is interesting to know that the bows found, during archaeological excavations at different sites in the country, reveal that Indians used composite bows made of wood, sinew, and horn as early as the eleventh century, at least 500 years before such bows were made in medieval Europe. The versatility of composites, in the sense that they possess very desirable structural, thermal, electrical, chemical and mechanical properties, fascinated me. I was so enthused with these man-made materials that I was in a hurry to know everything about them almost overnight. I used to read up everything available on related topics. I was particularly interested in the glass and carbon Fibre Reinforced Plastic (FRP) composites.

An FRP composite is composed of an inorganic fibre woven into a matrix that encloses it and gives the component its bulk form. In February 1969, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi visited Thumba to dedicate TERLS to the International Space Science Community. On this occasion, she commissioned the country’s first filament winding machine in our laboratory. This event brought my team,